NIKHAT ZAREEN, 26 | Boxing (50kg), (GOLD)

A Meteoric Rise



AP

"Who is Nikhat Zareen?" Mary Kom had asked sarcastically in 2019 when the boxer from Nizamabad had taken to social media to request a national trial to face the legend and hopefully earn a ticket to the Tokyo Olympics. Zareen lost the bout but not her determination to succeed. Two years later, with three gold medals in 2022 alone, including the World Championships in May and the dominant performance in the Commonwealth Games, India knows who Nikhat Zareen is. Given her talent and personality, they are unlikely to forget too.

Breaking barriers comes naturally to Zareen, who became one of the first Muslim women to represent India internationally in boxing. In this, her father's role was paramount. Mohammed Jameel Ahmed set social objections aside, including that of his wife, to encourage his teenage daughter and trained her initially. Zareen rose fast, becoming the 2011 world junior champion, only to see the momentum swing after a shoulder injury kept her out of the ring for over a year. With Kom in the twilight of her career and given Zareen's stellar run, she remains to be one of India's biggest medal contenders in Paris 2024. —*SS*



JEREMY LALRINNUNGA, 19 | Weightlifting (67 kg), GOLD

No Pain, No Gain

A hero's welcome awaited Jeremy in Aizawl, Mizoram, after he won gold in the 67 kg weight category, setting a Games record in the process. It was a long due trip given the youngster has been away from his parents and five siblings for long spells training at Netaji Subhas National Institute of Sports in Patiala under the guidance of Vijay Sharma, also coach of Olympic silver medallist Mirabai Chanu. Lalrinnunga was seen as the next big thing in the sport after strong showings at the junior level, including the first Indian to win gold at the Youth Olympic Games in 2018. Injuries have plagued his smooth transition to the seniors but his CWG performance offers proof that the future of Indian weightlifting is in sturdy hands. Paris 2024 can't come any sooner. –*SS*